

Consulting English Jargon Quick Reference

Field-specific terms, contrast pairs, and high-pressure sentence frames

Audience: management consultants, strategy consultants, implementation consultants, analysts, engagement managers, client partners, internal consultants, and advisory teams

Focus: A consulting English curriculum for discovery, hypotheses, stakeholder management, scope, executive recommendations, slide narratives, implementation risk, and client pushback.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who already use professional English and need industry-specific terminology, realistic meetings, role-play pressure, careful pushback, and polished workplace outputs.

Teaching stance: this is language and workplace-communication training, not legal, medical, financial, safety, or regulatory advice. Instructors should connect every scenario to the learner's current company policies, local rules, and approved procedures.

Nomenclature and Jargon

These are classroom working definitions. Learners should adapt wording to their organization's policies, systems, and local regulatory environment.

Client Discovery and Problem Definition

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
discovery	In consulting, discovery is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to clarify the real problem before proposing work.	clarify discovery; document discovery	Contrast: discovery should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify discovery and the evidence that supports it.
problem statement	In consulting, problem statement is a workplace communication artifact that records facts, interpretation, and the decision or action requested. Use it when teams need to clarify the real problem before proposing work.	prepare a problem statement; circulate the problem statement	Contrast: problem statement is a reviewable communication artifact, not an undocumented verbal assurance. Example: The problem statement should state the evidence, caveat, decision owner, and next action.
decision question	In consulting, decision question is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to clarify the real problem before proposing work.	clarify decision question; document decision question	Contrast: decision question should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify decision question and the evidence that supports it.
stakeholder	Person or group with an interest, risk, authority, or dependency in the work.	clarify stakeholder; document stakeholder	Contrast: stakeholder should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify stakeholder and the evidence that supports it.

Hypotheses and Issue Trees

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
hypothesis	In consulting, hypothesis is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to structure analysis without pretending certainty.	clarify hypothesis; document hypothesis	Contrast: hypothesis should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify hypothesis and the evidence that supports it.
issue tree	In consulting, issue tree is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to structure analysis without pretending certainty.	clarify issue tree; document issue tree	Contrast: issue tree should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify issue tree and the evidence that supports it.
workstream	In consulting, workstream is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to structure analysis without pretending certainty.	clarify workstream; document workstream	Contrast: workstream should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify workstream and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
evidence plan	In consulting, evidence plan is a structured course of action that assigns priorities, sequencing, assumptions, and responsible roles. Use it when teams need to structure analysis without pretending certainty.	align on the evidence plan; revise the evidence plan	Contrast: evidence plan sets an intended course of action; it is not proof that the work is feasible or approved. Example: Before we revise the evidence plan, we need to test the dependency and resource assumptions.

Data Requests and Client Burden

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
data request	In consulting, data request is a formal intake or routing mechanism that starts work, seeks a decision, or transfers responsibility. Use it when teams need to ask for information efficiently and respectfully.	clarify data request; document data request	Contrast: data request should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify data request and the evidence that supports it.
confidentiality	In consulting, confidentiality is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to ask for information efficiently and respectfully.	clarify confidentiality; document confidentiality	Contrast: confidentiality should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify confidentiality and the evidence that supports it.
owner	Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.	clarify owner; document owner	Contrast: owner should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify owner and the evidence that supports it.
deadline	In consulting, deadline is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to ask for information efficiently and respectfully.	clarify deadline; document deadline	Contrast: deadline should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify deadline and the evidence that supports it.

Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
storyline	In consulting, storyline is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to turn analysis into a clear recommendation.	clarify storyline; document storyline	Contrast: storyline should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify storyline and the evidence that supports it.
so what	In consulting, so what is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to turn analysis into a clear recommendation.	clarify so what; document so what	Contrast: so what should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify so what and the evidence that supports it.
recommendation	In consulting, recommendation is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to turn analysis into a clear recommendation.	clarify recommendation; document recommendation	Contrast: recommendation should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify recommendation and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
decision ask	In consulting, decision ask is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to turn analysis into a clear recommendation.	clarify decision ask; document decision ask	Contrast: decision ask should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify decision ask and the evidence that supports it.

Scope Management and Change Requests

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
scope	Defined boundary of work, responsibility, deliverables, assumptions, and exclusions.	clarify scope; document scope	Contrast: scope should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify scope and the evidence that supports it.
change request	In consulting, change request is a formal intake or routing mechanism that starts work, seeks a decision, or transfers responsibility. Use it when teams need to protect scope while staying client-service oriented.	clarify change request; document change request	Contrast: change request should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify change request and the evidence that supports it.
tradeoff	In consulting, tradeoff is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to protect scope while staying client-service oriented.	clarify tradeoff; document tradeoff	Contrast: tradeoff should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify tradeoff and the evidence that supports it.
statement of work	In consulting, statement of work is a workplace communication artifact that records facts, interpretation, and the decision or action requested. Use it when teams need to protect scope while staying client-service oriented.	prepare a statement of work; circulate the statement of work	Contrast: statement of work is a reviewable communication artifact, not an undocumented verbal assurance. Example: The statement of work should state the evidence, caveat, decision owner, and next action.

Difficult Client Feedback

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
assumption	In consulting, assumption is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to receive criticism without losing authority.	clarify assumption; document assumption	Contrast: assumption should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify assumption and the evidence that supports it.
implementation constraint	In consulting, implementation constraint is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to receive criticism without losing authority.	clarify implementation constraint; document implementation constraint	Contrast: implementation constraint should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify implementation constraint and the evidence that supports it.
stakeholder buy-in	In consulting, stakeholder buy-in is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to receive criticism without losing authority.	clarify stakeholder buy-in; document stakeholder buy-in	Contrast: stakeholder buy-in should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify stakeholder buy-in and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
iteration	In consulting, iteration is a measurable indicator used to quantify performance, exposure, capacity, quality, or change over time. Use it when teams need to receive criticism without losing authority.	track iteration; explain a change in iteration	Contrast: iteration measures a result or condition; it does not, by itself, prove the cause. Example: Before we act, let us track iteration by segment and explain what changed.

Implementation and Change Management

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
operating model	How work is organized across people, process, technology, governance, and metrics.	clarify operating model; document operating model	Contrast: operating model should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify operating model and the evidence that supports it.
change management	In consulting, change management is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to move from recommendation to adoption risk.	clarify change management; document change management	Contrast: change management should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify change management and the evidence that supports it.
adoption	In consulting, adoption is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to move from recommendation to adoption risk.	clarify adoption; document adoption	Contrast: adoption should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify adoption and the evidence that supports it.
decision rights	In consulting, decision rights is a decision-accountability mechanism that clarifies who recommends, approves, performs, and accepts risk. Use it when teams need to move from recommendation to adoption risk.	clarify decision rights; document decision rights	Contrast: decision rights should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify decision rights and the evidence that supports it.

Steering Committees and Final Readouts

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
steering committee	In consulting, steering committee is a decision-accountability mechanism that clarifies who recommends, approves, performs, and accepts risk. Use it when teams need to manage executive decisions and unresolved disagreement.	clarify steering committee; document steering committee	Contrast: steering committee should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify steering committee and the evidence that supports it.
option set	In consulting, option set is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to manage executive decisions and unresolved disagreement.	clarify option set; document option set	Contrast: option set should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify option set and the evidence that supports it.
risk	In consulting, risk is a condition or event that can create harm, loss, noncompliance, delay, or unacceptable performance. Use it when teams need to manage executive decisions and unresolved disagreement.	assess risk; mitigate risk	Contrast: risk identifies a possible or current exposure; it is not the same as accepting that exposure. Example: We need to assess risk, name the owner, and agree on the trigger for escalation.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
next step	In consulting, next step is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to manage executive decisions and unresolved disagreement.	clarify next step; document next step	Contrast: next step should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify next step and the evidence that supports it.

Industry-Specific Meeting Moves

Situation	Useful language
Client Discovery and Problem Definition	Before we commit, I want to confirm discovery, problem statement, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If decision question, stakeholders, constraints, and expected use of analysis need clarification., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Hypotheses and Issue Trees	Before we commit, I want to confirm hypothesis, issue tree, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If hypotheses, issue tree, prioritization, and evidence plan should focus effort., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Data Requests and Client Burden	Before we commit, I want to confirm data request, confidentiality, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If data relevance, owner, confidentiality, deadline, and burden need management., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis	Before we commit, I want to confirm storyline, so what, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If so-what, implication, recommendation, and decision ask must be explicit., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Scope Management and Change Requests	Before we commit, I want to confirm scope, change request, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If scope, timeline, budget, value, and tradeoff need a formal conversation., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Difficult Client Feedback	Before we commit, I want to confirm assumption, implementation constraint, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If implementation constraints, assumptions, and client knowledge should be integrated., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Implementation and Change Management	Before we commit, I want to confirm operating model, change management, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If change story, incentives, decision rights, training, and adoption metrics matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Steering Committees and Final Readouts	Before we commit, I want to confirm steering committee, option set, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If decision rights, options, risks, and next-step ownership need facilitation., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.

High-pressure pushback frames

- I understand the urgency. The risk is that we move faster than the evidence or process supports.
- I am not blocking the goal. I am naming the condition we need before the decision is safe and credible.
- If we accept this risk, we should name the owner, document the assumption, and define the trigger for escalation.
- That may be possible, but not under the current scope, timeline, or approval path.
- Let's separate what we know, what we assume, and what still needs confirmation.

Contrast Pairs

Do not confuse	Useful distinction
discovery vs stakeholder	In client discovery and problem definition, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.

Do not confuse	Useful distinction
hypothesis vs evidence plan	In hypotheses and issue trees, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
data request vs deadline	In data requests and client burden, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
storyline vs decision ask	In slide storylines and executive synthesis, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
scope vs statement of work	In scope management and change requests, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
assumption vs iteration	In difficult client feedback, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
operating model vs decision rights	In implementation and change management, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
steering committee vs next step	In steering committees and final readouts, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.